

Guide 21 — Title Examiner and Property Records Specialist

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What this career is

Title examiners, abstractors, searchers, and property-records specialists research recorded information about real property. Depending on the employer and jurisdiction, the work may include locating deeds, mortgages, liens, judgments, easements, restrictions, legal descriptions, tax records, probate or court records, and other recorded instruments; tracing chains of title; comparing names, parcel identifiers, and legal descriptions; documenting exceptions or inconsistencies; and preparing factual reports for authorized reviewers.

The occupation is detail-intensive and can be a practical pathway for people who like research, records, legal documents, real estate, and structured problem solving. It can exist in title companies, law firms, lenders, local government, land registries, real-estate service firms, and related organizations.

This work is not the same thing as being an attorney, notary, registrar, recorder, escrow officer, closing agent, conveyancer, or title-insurance underwriter. A job title does not by itself create legal, insurance, closing, or government authority.

What you may do in an entry or developing role

Typical support work may include:

- searching public or authorized property-record systems;
- locating and organizing recorded instruments;
- comparing names, dates, document numbers, legal descriptions, and parcel identifiers;
- identifying recorded mortgages, liens, judgments, easements, restrictions, or other items for further review;
- preparing factual abstracts, worksheets, checklists, or research summaries;
- documenting gaps, conflicts, or items that require escalation;
- using employer title plants, document-management systems, GIS tools, county or registry portals, and office software;
- following privacy, security, retention, and quality-control procedures; and
- routing legal, underwriting, ownership, priority, or closing questions to the appropriately authorized person.

The safest professional habit is to distinguish a fact found in an authoritative record from a legal conclusion about what that fact means.

What you must not assume you are authorized to do

Do not assume that training or employment as a title examiner or records specialist authorizes you to:

- give legal advice or a legal opinion on ownership or marketable title;
- determine lien priority without the required authorized review;
- sell, solicit, negotiate, issue, or underwrite title insurance unless properly authorized and licensed where required;
- perform attorney, notary, registrar, recorder, escrow, settlement, conveyancing, or closing functions that local law reserves to others;
- alter official land or property records;
- certify that a private summary is equivalent to an official registry certificate; or
- upload customer, lender, escrow, identity, or other sensitive data into an external AI system merely because some related records are public.

Rules vary by country, state, province, territory, municipality, employer, and task. Verify the actual duties and authority before accepting regulated responsibilities or paying for specialized training.

Education and entry pathways

There is no single universal education requirement for this occupation in the United States. O*NET reports a mix of high-school-equivalent, postsecondary-certificate, and bachelor's-level entry pathways among respondents. Employers may value a combination of records research, real-estate knowledge, legal-document familiarity, office technology, accuracy, and local-system knowledge.

Useful fields of study can include:

- paralegal or legal studies;
- real estate;
- records and information management;
- public administration;
- business administration;
- GIS or mapping fundamentals;
- document management;
- office technology; and
- data privacy and information security.

A short course can build skills, but it should not be described as a license unless the issuing authority explicitly says it is one.

A practical low-cost learning sequence

Weeks 1-2: Learn the vocabulary

Study basic real-property records terminology: deed, grantor, grantee, mortgage or deed of trust, lien, judgment, easement, restriction, legal description, parcel identifier, chain of title, recording date, instrument number, and tax record.

Use plain-language glossaries from official government, court, registry, or reputable educational sources. Keep a personal glossary and write one-sentence definitions in your own words.

Weeks 3-4: Practice record organization

Build a fictional property file using sample or openly available documents. Practice naming files consistently, recording source and date, distinguishing a document number from a parcel number, and creating a chronological index.

Do not use a real person's sensitive information for practice unless you are authorized to do so.

Weeks 5-6: Learn local public-record systems

Identify the official property-record authority where you live or expect to work. Learn which records are official, which are informational copies, how corrections are handled, and what fees or access restrictions apply.

In the United States, this may involve county or municipal recorder, clerk, assessor, court, tax, or GIS systems. In Canada, land-registration systems and occupational requirements differ by province and territory. In Colombia, use official Superintendencia de Notariado y Registro and related authorized systems rather than treating U.S. title-insurance procedures as interchangeable.

Weeks 7-8: Build a quality-control routine

Practice checking names, dates, legal descriptions, parcel identifiers, document references, and gaps. Create a two-column worksheet: "recorded fact" and "question requiring review." This helps prevent factual research from drifting into unauthorized legal conclusions.

Weeks 9-10: Add privacy and security

Learn your employer's rules for customer information, authentication, acceptable use, document retention, secure sharing, and AI tools. Public availability of one record does not automatically authorize aggregation, republication, retention, or use of related nonpublic customer information.

Weeks 11-12: Prepare an employment portfolio

Create a small portfolio using fictional or public-domain sample material. Include a chronology, document index, discrepancy log, source list, and a short explanation of your escalation rules. Never include confidential employer or customer data.

United States pathway

ONET classifies **Title Examiners, Abstractors, and Searchers** under occupation 23-2093.00. Current ONET workforce data report 2025 median wages of **\$28.20 per hour** and 58,650 *per year*, with a 10th–to–90th–percentile annual range of ***\$38,170 to \$90,830**. O*NET reports 57,400 workers in 2024, projected 2024–2034 growth of 1%–2%, and approximately 5,400 projected openings over that period.

These are occupation-level estimates, not a promise of earnings. Actual pay depends on geography, employer, experience, duties, schedule, licensing responsibilities, and market conditions.

Current non-government U.S. income estimates

Private salary sources use different samples and methods and should be read as supplemental market signals rather than official statistics.

- **Indeed — Title Examiner:** \$60,541 per year average base salary, based on 184 salary observations from job postings over the prior 36 months; page stated updated July 17, 2026. Verified August 10, 2026.
- **ZipRecruiter — Title Examiner:** \$51,098 per year average, approximately \$24.57 per hour, stated as of July 27, 2026; its reported central range included approximately 38,000–59,500 for the 25th–75th percentiles. Verified August 10, 2026.

Do not average these figures into one supposedly authoritative salary. Differences can reflect title, geography, experience, sample window, employer mix, and methodology.

Licensing boundary in the United States

Insurance licensing is state-based. The National Association of Insurance Commissioners states that people who sell, solicit, or negotiate insurance must be licensed as insurance producers, and its licensing materials include title-insurance agents. Therefore, title research or examination experience should never be presented as automatic authority to sell, issue, negotiate, or underwrite title insurance.

Check the state insurance regulator and employer before performing regulated insurance functions.

Canada pathway

Government of Canada Job Bank maps title-searcher and land-titles-examiner work to the broader **NOC 42200, Paralegals and related occupations**. The current national wage display reports approximately **CAD \$21.63/hour low, \$33.05/hour median, and \$52.19/hour high**, based on the displayed reference period and updated November 19, 2025.

This occupational mapping is broader than a single title-search job. Requirements may include legal or paralegal education, employer or industry training, experience, and—where the duties involve regulated legal services—provincial licensing or other authorization.

Before paying for a program, verify:

1. the province or territory where you intend to work;
2. the actual job duties;
3. whether the role is employee support, registry work, independent legal service, or another regulated function;
4. employer requirements; and
5. current provincial land-registration and legal-services rules.

Colombia pathway

Colombia uses its own property-registration framework and should not be treated as a translated version of the U.S. title-insurance system.

The **Superintendencia de Notariado y Registro (SNR)** administers the public-registration system and Offices of Public Instruments Registration. The **Certificado de Tradición y Libertad** is an official service used to know the registered legal situation and history of real property. **Ley 1579 de 2012** establishes the Statute of Registration of Public Instruments.

A realistic Colombian pathway can include records administration, document control, legal-office support, real-estate administrative work, public-record research, or registry-adjacent roles where the employer provides task-specific training. Workers should rely on SNR/VUR and other authoritative systems for official records and should not represent a privately prepared summary, screenshot, database extract, or AI output as an official certificate or registrar action.

Free or low-cost Colombia training

SENA is a primary public training source to check before paying for commercial training. During the 2026 revision research, SENA Betowa listed a **48-hour complementary course in Organización de archivos de gestión**. This is useful foundational records training, not a title-examiner license, legal credential, registry appointment, or substitute for employer-specific instruction.

SENA offerings and enrollment windows change. Verify current availability directly before planning around a specific course.

Other Latin America pathways

Land-registration, notarial, cadastral, and conveyancing systems differ substantially across Latin America. Begin with the country's official land registry, cadastre, justice, notarial, or property authority and identify the local occupational equivalent before choosing training.

Useful transferable skills include:

- document indexing and records management;
- legal and real-estate vocabulary;
- spreadsheet accuracy;
- GIS and parcel-reference basics;
- customer-service documentation;

- privacy and data-handling discipline;
- quality assurance; and
- bilingual terminology where relevant.

Do not assume that a U.S., Canadian, Colombian, or other country's credential or job title automatically transfers legal authority across borders.

Funding, scholarships, apprenticeships, and employer support

United States

Before self-funding, check **CareerOneStop**, your local **American Job Center**, and **WIOA** eligibility. Depending on local rules and provider eligibility, workforce funding may support legal studies, records, GIS, office technology, real-estate, or related training. Funding is not automatic; confirm eligibility and provider status in writing.

Check **Apprenticeship.gov** for current related opportunities. O*NET links learners to the federal apprenticeship finder, but a title-examiner apprenticeship should not be assumed to exist in every location or at every time.

Ask employers whether they provide paid onboarding, proprietary title-plant training, recording-system training, continuing education, tuition assistance, certification reimbursement, or cross-training. Treat employer support as something to verify, not a guaranteed benefit.

Canada

Check provincial employment services, public colleges, workforce programs, employer reimbursement, and current scholarships before buying private training. Because requirements vary by province and duty, confirm that any program is recognized for the work you actually intend to perform.

Latin America

Prioritize public technical education, national or regional employment services, employer training, and official scholarship programs before commercial bootcamps. In Colombia, check SENA first for relevant free or low-cost records, administrative, digital, customer-service, and document-management offerings.

Using AI safely in property-record work

AI can be useful for:

- explaining terminology in plain language;
- creating study plans and quizzes;
- drafting non-authoritative checklists;
- organizing fictional practice files;
- suggesting fields for a document index; and
- drafting a neutral summary that a human will verify.

AI should **not** be treated as the authoritative source for ownership, lien priority, legal descriptions, marketability of title, current record status, underwriting decisions, closing instructions, or registrar actions.

For high-impact facts, verify against authoritative records and obtain review from the appropriately authorized professional or official when required. Do not upload sensitive or nonpublic customer, property, lender, escrow, identity, or financial information to an external AI system unless the organization has explicitly authorized that use and applicable privacy, confidentiality, security, contractual, and retention requirements are satisfied.

Privacy and information-security habits

Use data minimization. Collect only what you need, use approved systems, protect credentials, follow retention rules, and avoid copying personal data into personal notes or unapproved tools.

In the United States, the FTC Safeguards Rule applies to covered financial institutions and requires safeguards for customer information. Coverage depends on activities, not merely a company's label. In Colombia, personal-data rights and SNR habeas-data requirements reinforce the need to handle identity and property-linked personal information carefully.

Employer policy and local law control the specific rules for your role.

What employers may look for

Common strengths include:

- exceptional attention to detail;
- ability to compare documents without guessing;
- consistent documentation;
- research persistence;
- comfort with repetitive quality checks;
- clear escalation of uncertainty;
- confidentiality and security discipline;
- basic spreadsheet and office-software skill;
- ability to learn local record systems; and
- professional written communication.

A candidate who says "I found this recorded fact, and I escalated the legal conclusion" is demonstrating safer judgment than one who overstates authority.

Questions to ask before accepting training or a job

Ask:

1. What exact records and systems will I use?
2. Which tasks are research support, and which require a licensed or otherwise authorized professional?

3. Does this role involve title insurance, escrow, settlement, closing, conveyancing, or independent legal services?
4. What licenses or appointments are required in this jurisdiction?
5. Does the employer train new hires on local systems and procedures?
6. Is training paid, reimbursed, or tied to a repayment agreement?
7. What privacy, retention, and AI-use rules apply?
8. How is quality reviewed before a report is relied on?
9. Are compensation figures base pay only, or do they include overtime, commission, or bonuses?
10. What happens if duties expand into regulated work?

When to pause before paying for training

Pause or delay payment when:

- the provider promises guaranteed employment or income;
- the provider calls a course a license without identifying the government or professional authority that issues it;
- the curriculum teaches one jurisdiction as though it applies everywhere;
- employer requirements in your target market have not been checked;
- funding, scholarship, reimbursement, cancellation, or repayment terms are not in writing;
- the program encourages learners to give legal conclusions beyond their authority; or
- the training encourages uploading confidential records to public AI tools without organizational approval.

Source register

Official and primary sources used for the controlled 2026 revision include:

- O*NET OnLine, Title Examiners, Abstractors, and Searchers, occupation 23-2093.00: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/23-2093.00>
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wages 23-2093: <https://www.bls.gov/oes/2023/may/oes232093.htm>
- National Association of Insurance Commissioners, Producer Licensing: <https://content.naic.org/insurance-topics/producer-licensing>
- NAIC State Licensing Handbook: https://content.naic.org/state_licensing_handbook.htm
- Federal Trade Commission, Safeguards Rule: <https://www.ftc.gov/legal-library/browse/rules/safeguards-rule>
- FTC business guidance on the Safeguards Rule: <https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/ftc-safeguards-rule-what-your-business-needs-know>
- Government of Canada Job Bank, Title Searcher wages and requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/16033/ca> and <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/16033/ca>

- Superintendencia de Notariado y Registro, services and legal framework: <https://www.supernotariado.gov.co/atencion-servicios-ciudadania/tramites-y-servicios/> and <https://www.supernotariado.gov.co/transparencia/leyes/>
- SNR Habeas Data: <https://www.supernotariado.gov.co/transparencia/habeas-data/>
- SENA Betowa, Organización de archivos de gestión: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/organizacion-de-archivos-de-gestion>
- CareerOneStop WIOA training finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>
- Apprenticeship.gov: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/>

Supplementary non-government income sources:

- Indeed, Title Examiner salaries: <https://www.indeed.com/career/title-examiner/salaries>
- ZipRecruiter, Title Examiner salary: <https://www.ziprecruiter.com/Salaries/Title-Examiner-Salary>

Important limitations

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